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Writing women's worlds

Author(S): Abu-Lughod, Lila

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 235

Culture (OWC): [Libyan Bedouin \(MT09\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Northern Africa

Field Date: 1978-1989

Coverage Date: 1978-1989

Place Coverage: Western Desert, Egypt

Section Title(S): Piety

Their reactions to the sanctimonious Egyptians—and now to some Bedouins from the cities, who were becoming, as they put it, “followers of the model,” meaning the life of the Prophet—have been mixed. The older women are not cowed. They argue, as Kamla did, that they have always worn modest clothing and covered their hair with a headcloth. They resent being told that some of the ways they have demonstrated their devoutness are wrong.

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Kamla is more unsure. Sometimes she defends these Muslim Sisters and Brothers and sometimes she goes along with the old Bedouin women as they make fun of them. One evening, having recited some poetry and told some traditional tales for my benefit, Kamla’s aunt Dhahab turned to her niece and asked, “Hey Kamla, have you given Lila any songs?”

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Kamla was coy. “I’m not a song person. I’m just a simple person minding my own business. I’m with God. I’m pious and know my Lord.”

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Her sister hooted, perhaps thinking of Kamla’s love of the radio and scandalous movie magazines. But Kamla went on, only half joking, “Auntie,

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I've become pious. I don't have anything to do with songs."

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Her aunt mocked her, "What's this? You've become pious?" Everyone laughed as the old aunt continued, "God's blessings! God's blessings! So, you're joining the 'Beard Family'?"

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There was a commotion, with everyone talking at once about the topic that was so often in the air these days: the Islamists. Kamla spoke on their behalf. "They say, 'We are religious people,... following God's path, the path to heaven.'"

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